

Our Carbon Credit Ratings Framework for **Biochar Projects**

Incentivizing investment in real climate action

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Introduction

Sylvera Ratings are the most reliable and trustworthy in the market.

Sylvera has developed a rigorous bottom-up approach in order to produce the most accurate ratings and analyses for projects in the carbon markets.

What sets Sylvera apart

- **Project-type-specific frameworks:** We build rigorous frameworks and production systems for every project category to accurately test project design, carbon accounting, and climate impact claims.

Sylvera's frameworks are peer-reviewed by a committee of experts and carbon market stakeholders – including project developers & registries – to ensure scientific consensus. We have published this document so buyers understand how we developed our unique, nuanced framework, and we have included some examples of exactly what we test and how we do it.

[Read our white paper for more information.](#)

- **Unparalleled depth & accuracy:** We extract, clean, and organize data from project design documentation (PDD) and every monitoring report. Then we meticulously build carbon, strength of baseline and financial additionality models from the ground up to validate emissions reductions or removals claims and evaluate project economics.

Our project assessments are the most comprehensive in the market, providing granular analysis of core project characteristics, insightful data visualizations, and interactive maps.

- **Independent Data Validation:** Our expert analysts leverage advanced machine learning (ML) technology, verified, independent data, and proprietary field data to test the accuracy of credit issuances and claims.

The comparison of independent data specific to each project against the data reported in the project's documentation is the cornerstone of high quality due diligence.

Key terms and concepts

Biochar	Biochar is a stable organic carbon compound formed through pyrolysis.
Biochar Decay Rate	Decay rate refers to the speed at which biochar's stored carbon is released back into the atmosphere due to environmental and external factors such as soil conditions and temperature, application methods, and natural risks.
Biochar Stability Rate	Stability rate measures the longevity of biochar's carbon storage, indicating how effectively it resists degradation and remains sequestered over time, typically for periods exceeding 100 years.
Carbon credit	A tradable unit representing one metric ton of carbon dioxide (CO ₂), or an equivalent amount of another greenhouse gas (GHG), avoided or removed from Earth's atmosphere.
Greenhouse Gas (GHG) Emissions	Refers to the release of gases into the atmosphere that trap heat and contribute to climate change.
Hydrogen to Carbon Ratio (H/C)	The hydrogen to carbon ratio correlates with the stability of biochar.
Internal Rate of Return (IRR)	Internal Rate of Return used for investment analysis to estimate the return on an investment.
Life Cycle Assessment (LCA)	This refers to the analysis conducted to estimate the amount of emissions associated with the sourcing of biomass, the creation of biochar and its deployment.
Over-crediting risk	This refers to the risk that the project has issued credits in excess of what is justifiable against the business as usual scenario.
Oxygen to Carbon Ratio (O/C)	The oxygen to carbon ratio correlates with the stability of biochar.
Permanence Adjustment Factor	This refers to the percentage of carbon that will stay secure in the biochar for the next 100 years.
Project emissions	Emissions associated with ongoing operations of the carbon credit project.
Pyrolysis	Pyrolysis is the heating/burning of an element in an oxygen-absent, controlled environment.
Vintage	This refers to the year, or timeframe, associated with an issued carbon credit.

The state of Biochar

The challenge

Biochar is an essential technology to help scale the engineered Carbon Dioxide Removal (CDR) market and meet the growing demand for carbon removal credits. The majority of delivered CDR credits, ones which are validated and issued, are from biochar projects. This means that biochar credits are some of the only technology CDR credits companies can purchase and retire to compensate for their emissions.

Biochar developers and registries are nascent and ultimately have yet to face the same scrutiny as other sectors of the market. For biochar projects there is a notable deficiency of data available around key project performance parameters. The rush to procure biochar credits is understandable, but without transparency and deep due diligence the credits represent a material risk in your carbon credit portfolio.

With the right data disclosures and collaboration with developers, we can provide the deep project-level insights needed to inform buyers' investment due diligence and help bring **these technologies** to scale faster. If you're a project developer interested in having Sylvera rate your project to help prove impact and optimize investment, reach out to our [team](#).

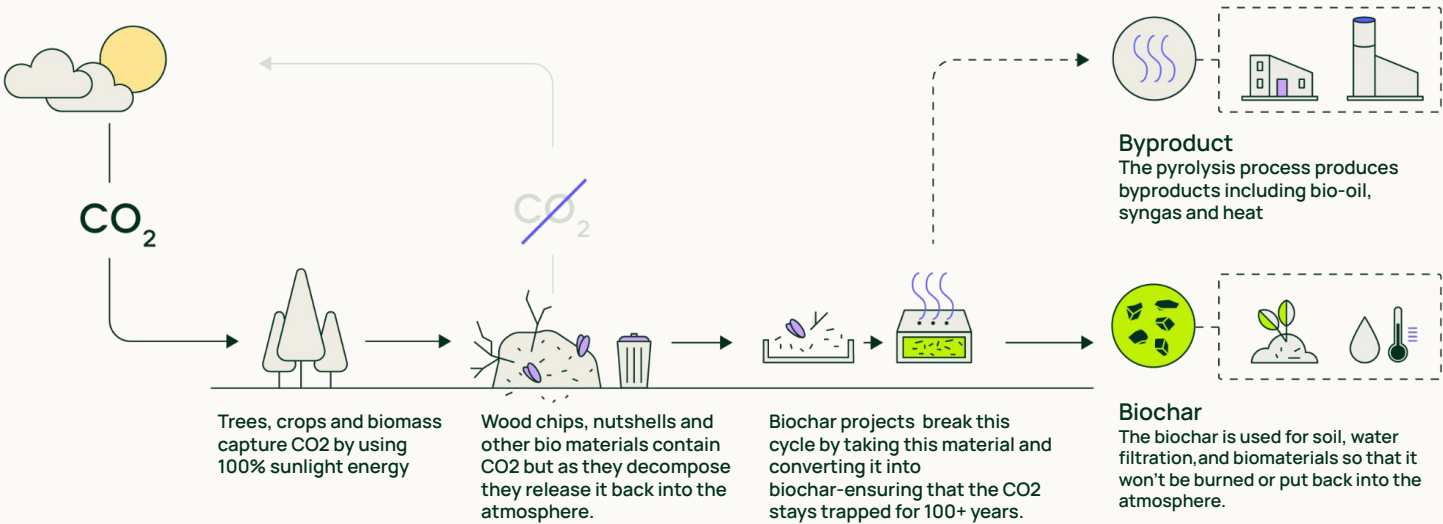
The solution

To overcome the challenge of data transparency and scale the biochar market, the following data points are needed to ensure trust in biochar credits:

1. **Investment Analysis Parameters:** Disclosing financial parameters allows the market to assess whether carbon finance is necessary for the project to be economic. Without this data, the financial additionality is uncertain.
2. **Biochar Carbon Content:** The amount of carbon present in the biochar created is the foundation of the net carbon sequestration calculations.
3. **Permanence Adjustment Factor:** The permanence adjustment factor used for decay of biochar is necessary to verify the emissions calculations and the amount of carbon secured in the biochar over the next 100 years.
4. **H/C Ratio:** The ratio of hydrogen to organic carbon, based on lab analysis, is a key factor in the quantification of the volume of credits issued and the stability of carbon sequestered.
5. **Feedstock:** Disclosing the feedstock type, sourcing principles and feedstock counterfactual related to the project is important in understanding impacts associated with feedstocks, and this can have a big impact on the net removal calculation.
6. **LCA Emissions:** Life cycle assessments (LCA) demonstrate whether emissions associated with the creation and deployment of biochar have been accounted for in full. Emissions at each stage of the life cycle should be made available to determine any risk of over-crediting.
7. **Geographic Coordinates:** Project developers should disclose the location and geographic coordinates of the end-use applications of biochar to enable effective monitoring and evaluation of reversal risks and decay rates.

What is a Biochar project?

Biochar projects produce **removals credits** that aim to maximize the production of biochar predominantly through pyrolysis. Not all carbon is converted to biochar during the pyrolysis process; bio-gas and syngas are also produced. The biochar produced is abundant in carbon, stable and has numerous applications. The stability of the biochar is based on the temperature at which it was created and the resulting H/C and O/C ratio.



The input to the process is primarily plant and animal biomass. The biomass can be sourced locally from the surrounding forests or agricultural lands and may come from many sources, for example a forest management company with wood chips or a farmer with grass and crop residue. The sourced biomass has a direct impact on the quality of the biochar created. This input has to be dried and prepared for the pyrolysis plant.

The pyrolysis plant heats up the biomass in the absence of oxygen at high temperatures (up to 800C). The process creates other co-products such as bio-oil, syngas and excess thermal energy, which can be sold for additional revenue streams. Alternative revenue streams, in addition to those derived from the sale of carbon credits, have meaningful implications for the **additionality of biochar projects** as these revenue streams impact the extent to which carbon finance is required for these projects to be economic.

Biochar alternative use cases

Water filters & wastewater treatment	Building materials	Renewable heat
Added to soil (fertilizer, compost additive)	Animal farming (feed, slurry treatment)	Fabric additive in textiles

Biochar is predominantly used for soil application. Research has shown the addition of biochar can increase soil fertility and protect soil from natural risks such as flooding and erosion.

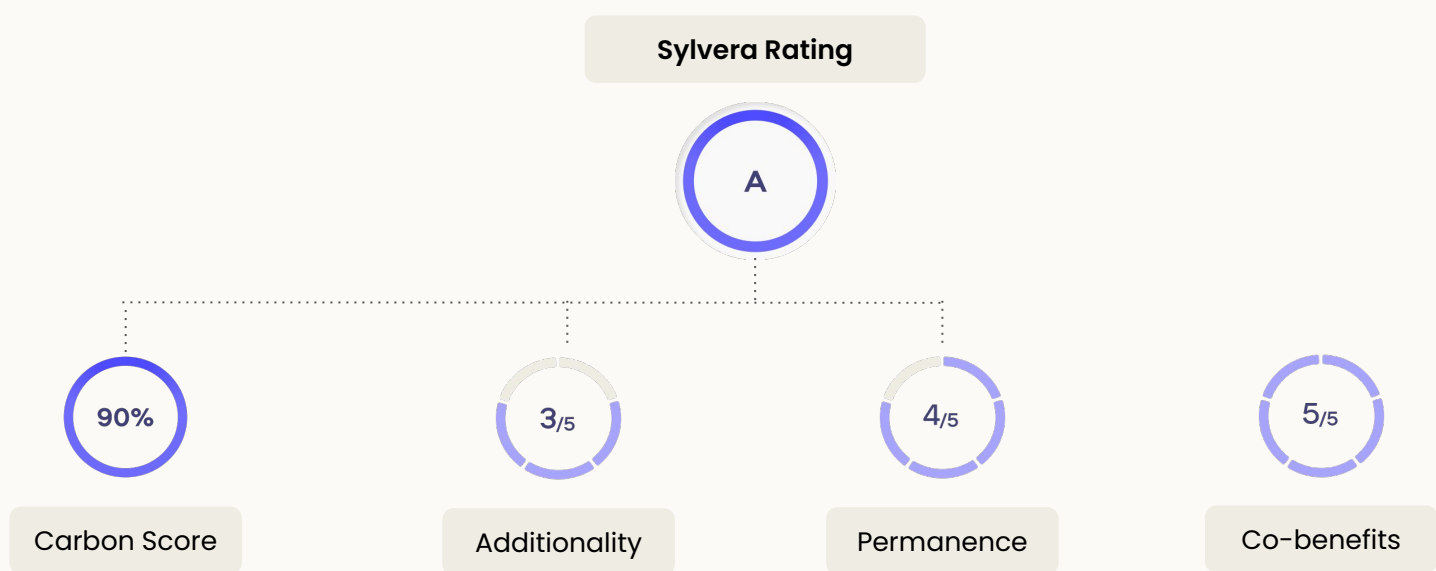
The carbon content of biochar **slightly decreases over the time** depending on its decay rate, the soil type and the temperature of the soil where the biochar is located. The rate of decomposition can increase based on the temperature of the soil. If the biochar is exposed to high temperatures for a long period of time, then it will decompose faster. In this case, there could be a potential **risk of over-crediting** of carbon credits if the high temperature is not accounted for appropriately by the project.

A reminder of our scoring pillars

Our top level Sylvera Ratings (**AAA, AA, A, BBB, BB, B, C, D**) reflect whether each credit associated with the project is likely to remove 1 metric ton of CO₂e emissions.

This rating is derived from a combination of scores that assess the **carbon** performance, **additionality** and **permanence** of the project. The scores in these three core pillars are combined in a series of matrices to ensure that underperformance in one key area does not get overshadowed by high performance in others.

Co-benefits are also assessed but they do not feed into the Sylvera Rating, as they do not have a direct bearing on the climate impact of carbon credits. Including them in the Sylvera Rating could lead to a high co-benefits score obscuring poor performance on carbon removal. Aspects of the project relating to co-benefits that could materially impact the project's ability to deliver it's stated climate benefit are, however, reflected in the Sylvera Rating.



Carbon Score	Additionality Score	Permanence Score	Co-benefits Score
Sylvera's Carbon Score verifies whether the project has delivered on its carbon claims. This is done by assessing four sub-components: the gross removals achieved by the biochar, the project's LCA emissions, leakage caused by the project, and the feedstock counterfactual, as well as assessing the quality of the project's own LCA, and the quality of the data used by the project.	Sylvera's Additionality Score assesses the likelihood the project activities would have been implemented in absence of the carbon revenues. It also assess the potential impact of policies and regulations as well as the risk of double accounting.	Sylvera's Permanence Score assesses the risk that the removals will later be reversed and released back into the atmosphere. This is mainly based on the risk of biochar end-use, driven by its end use type, i.e., soil or non-soil applications, biochar durability and external factors such as natural risks, biochar application method etc., as well as anthropogenic risks.	Sylvera's Co-benefits Score assesses the scope and relative impact of project activities on local biodiversity and communities—which are linked to UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Carbon Score

What is it?

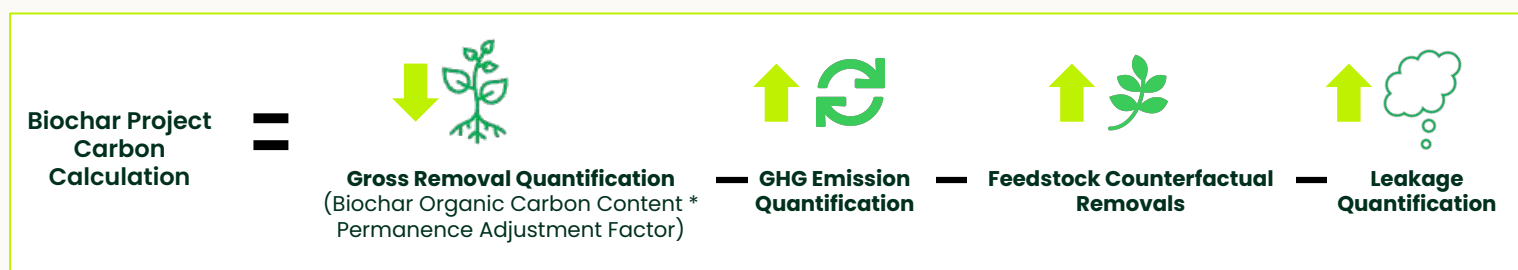
Sylvera's Carbon Score verifies whether a project is accurately reporting on the carbon removals achieved by the activity.

Note: The Carbon Score must be considered alongside the Additionality and Permanence Scores.

Why does it matter?

Accurate carbon accounting underpins the validity of a project's issuance and material under or over reporting of emissions will impact the number of credits that have been issued. If Sylvera-detected project carbon is significantly lower than the project's reported figures, reported carbon removal amounts are likely inaccurate and there is a higher risk of overissuance.

How do we calculate the Carbon Score?



Gross Removal Quantification

Sylvera replicates the project's Gross Removal Quantification by using the Biochar Decay Rate model. This model calculates a Permanence Adjustment Factor that reflects biochar decay over 100 years based on key factors such as soil temperature, biochar characteristics (including H/C ratio), and local conditions. The analysis ensures alignment with Sylvera's ensemble of independent third-party models, providing an accurate assessment of gross removals.

$$\text{Gross Removal} = Q_{\text{biochar}} \times C_{\text{org}} \times F_{p\ TH, Ts} \times 44/12$$

Where:

Q_{biochar} is the amount of biochar produced over the reporting period.

C_{org} is the organic carbon content of the biochar produced.

$F_{p\ TH, Ts}$ is the permanence factor of biochar organic carbon over a given time horizon TH in a given soil at temperature TS .

$$F_{p\ TH, Ts} = c + m \times H/C_{\text{org}}$$

Where:

c & m are constants used in the calculation of $F_{p\ TH, Ts}$

H/C_{org} is the molar ratio of hydrogen mass divided by organic carbon mass of the biochar

$44/12$ is the value used to convert mass of carbon to mass of carbon dioxide emissions

The Gross Removal Quantification is based on a Woolf et al. (2021) approach. It is important to use this approach to assess gross removals, as the quantity of removals remaining after 100 years will be lower at higher application temperatures. Therefore, by assessing the temperature at application, Sylvera can assess the size of removals that will be remaining.

Carbon Score continued

GHG Emission Quantification

To evaluate net carbon removals, Sylvera has developed an in-house Life Cycle Assessment (LCA) model, focusing on key emission sources including feedstock cultivation and transport, energy consumption, and construction. This proprietary LCA model identifies discrepancies between project reported emissions and Sylvera's calculations, assessing whether project-reported net removal values are robust and consistent. Sylvera's LCA model has been peer-reviewed by UCL Consultants, and uses the most up-to-date emission factors available from ecoinvent, as well as UK Government and other academic sources.

Emission calculations are performed by taking activity data, matching this to an emission factor, and multiplying these together to give an output in CO2 equivalent (CO2e):

$$\text{Activity data} \times \text{Emission Factor} = \text{kgCO}_2\text{e}$$

 **Electricity example:** 1000 kWh of purchased electricity $\times$ 0.27522 kgCO₂e/kWh = 275.22 kg CO₂e

Therefore, by performing these calculations across important emissions sources, Sylvera can assess whether the project is likely to be accurately reporting its GHG emissions.

Feedstock Counterfactual Quantification

Sylvera assesses the counterfactual scenario for feedstock use, determining whether the feedstock would have resulted in removals under a baseline scenario. By examining the type and alternative fate of feedstocks, Sylvera assesses whether the project has appropriately set their baseline value. In cases of uncertainty, conservative deductions are applied to ensure integrity in removal estimates.

Leakage Quantification

Sylvera evaluates the risk of leakage by analyzing the sourcing and usage of feedstocks, as well as potential indirect impacts such as land use changes or replacement emissions. The assessment ensures that leakage risk is investigated for removal claims. Where data is insufficient, Sylvera applies conservative deductions to uphold rigorous and transparent carbon accounting.

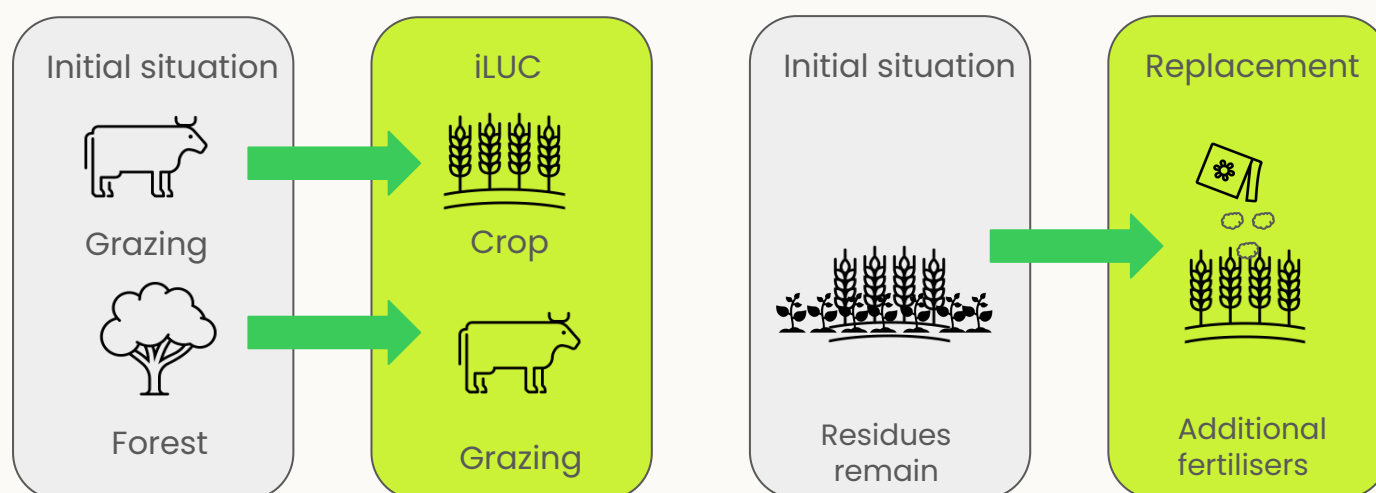


Figure 1. Examples of indirect Land Use Change (iLUC) and Replacement Emissions

Additionality Score

What is it?

Sylvera's additionality score assesses whether (1) a project would or wouldn't have been implemented in the absence of revenue generated through the sale of carbon credits, (2) the project is not mandatory/strongly supported by policies and regulations and (3) the project is not presenting double accounting risk with other VCM activities.

Why does it matter?

Additionality underpins the validity of credits issued by a project. If the project is not additional, then one credit purchased does not equate to one metric ton of carbon avoided and therefore yields no climate benefit above the business-as-usual (BAU) scenario.

A project would score high in additionality if Sylvera's financial analysis proves the need for carbon finance to make the project economic.

This is not a binary test and the degree of additionality depends on the carbon price required to make it economic. On the other hand, a project would score low in additionality if the revenues from biochar and any possible co-products (bio-oil, energy) are enough alone to make the project economically viable.

How does Sylvera assess additionality?

Financial Additionality

The assessment of financial additionality involves determining whether the economic viability of the project relies on offset revenues. Sylvera examines if the carbon credits revenue bridges the economic viability gap of the project through sensitivity analysis. Biochar projects that generate additional revenue streams by selling biochar or co-products to third parties, Sylvera assesses whether the project would still be economically viable without offset revenues. If a project is economically feasible without carbon credits, the credits are considered non-additional. This ensures that carbon finance is allocated only to projects that require it to proceed.

Biochar projects can have more than one revenue stream. The biochar itself can be sold for anywhere between USD \$300/tonne and \$1000/tonne based on the quality of the biochar and other transaction parameters. Furthermore, pyrolysis also creates thermal energy that can be sold along with any bio-oils produced during the process. These products can create significant revenues for the project crossing the hurdle rate required to make the project economic. If these revenues are not enough, carbon finance might be required to bridge this gap. However, reliance on high carbon credit prices can make the likelihood of achieving an IRR above the hurdle rate more difficult and unlikely.

A high quality project demonstrates the need for carbon finance to make the IRR of the project breach the hurdle rate with low carbon prices. Furthermore, the project should take into account any emissions associated with production of biochar and other products (bio-oil and energy) made possible through carbon finance.

Policy & Regulatory Landscape

Sylvera considers the policy and regulatory context to assess additionality. Projects are evaluated to confirm they are not mandated by law or regulation and to identify whether subsidies or government funding diminish their additionality. By integrating any provided subsidies or financial incentives into our economic analysis, Sylvera ensures that carbon credits are issued only where they play a critical role in making the project viable. This safeguards the integrity of credits in regions with supportive policy landscapes.

Double Accounting

To address the risk of double accounting, research are performed to ensure that carbon credits are not claimed by multiple stakeholders. In biochar projects, this involves verifying that the producer and end user of the biochar do not both claim the same carbon benefit. Clear documentation of credit allocation is required to establish ownership and avoid duplication. This approach safeguards the integrity and credibility of the issued credits.

Permanence Score

What is it?

Permanence refers to the risk that the sequestered carbon will later be reversed and released back into the atmosphere. The input of climatic variables, record of past events, project specific conditions and mitigative activities are used to inform the permanence risk scoring. Permanence is conceptualized as a scale that distinguishes the relative degree of non-permanence (or reversal) risk between projects.

Biochar credits credits have a low permanence risk given the overall high stability of biochar. The only case where biochar stability is uncertain is where there is a high likelihood and high severity of fire events, however in comparison to nature-based projects, there is significantly less risk of reversal.

The permanence of the carbon in the biochar is based on a variety of factors such as the random reflectance, the pyrolysis temperature and the H/C ratio. The biochar can also degrade based on the temperature of the soil where it is applied. The projects need to assess its biochar carbon storage to have permanence of at least for the next 100 years.

The soil type, location, and climatic conditions of a project significantly influence the long-term efficiency of biochar carbon sequestration. For instance, biochar decays faster in tropical climates like Brazil due to higher soil temperatures compared to cooler regions like Finland. Soil mineral content also plays a crucial role; soils with high mineral and water content, such as clay, enhance biochar permanence by supporting carbon mineralization and storage.

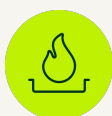
The end use and application of biochar must be traceable and monitored to quantify reversal risk. In soil applications, risk of reversal can be driven by fire or erosion from flooding or storm events.

For non-soil applications, the permanence is evaluated from its application lifespan across various use cases, such as biochar application in construction materials, water filtration systems, and energy applications. This involves examining how these different applications influence the durability and effectiveness of biochar in retaining carbon.

How do we calculate the permanence score?

The permanence score is derived from a comprehensive analysis of observational and modeled data, adhering to recognized methodologies and the latest scientific advancements. The permanence of biochar is significantly influenced by its end-use, whether applied in soil or non-soil environments. Sylvera's assessment evaluates biochar stability and decay rate in its specific application while also identifying anthropogenic risks associated with its use.

Stability rate



Random Reflectance

measures the amount of light reflected from biochar, indicating its level of carbonization



Pyrolysis temperature

reflects the temperature at which biochar is produced.



Hydrogen to Carbon (H/C) ratio

measure of elemental composition, where a lower ratio indicates more stable, aromatic carbon.

Decay rate



Natural risks

Events such as fire, flood, drought can have a direct negative impact on the decay rate of



Soil type and temperature

Soil with high mineral and water content may have higher permanence as it can mineralise and store carbon. In contrast, higher soil temperature leads to faster decay.



Soil application method

Different application methods such as subsurface soil application, blending with manure or fertilizer etc. will contribute to different levels of permanence.

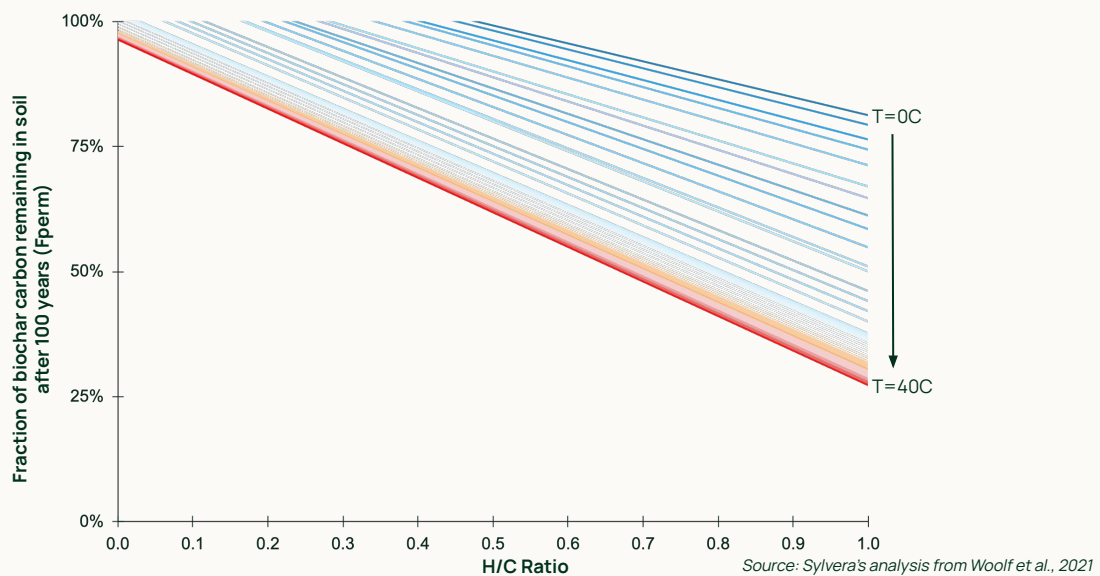
Permanence Score continued

What data do we use in the Permanence Score?

A component of the Stability Rate: the H/C ratio assessment

We assess biochar's permanence from their H/C ratio in different soil temperatures, using the analysis done by Woolf et. al, (2021). This analysis calculates the fraction of biochar carbon remaining in soil after 100 years (F_{perm}) in different soil temperatures. As seen in figure below, the higher the soil temperature, the steeper its decay line across the H/C ratio. Sylvera assesses the project's H/C ratio in combination with its soil temperature to determine its F_{perm} .

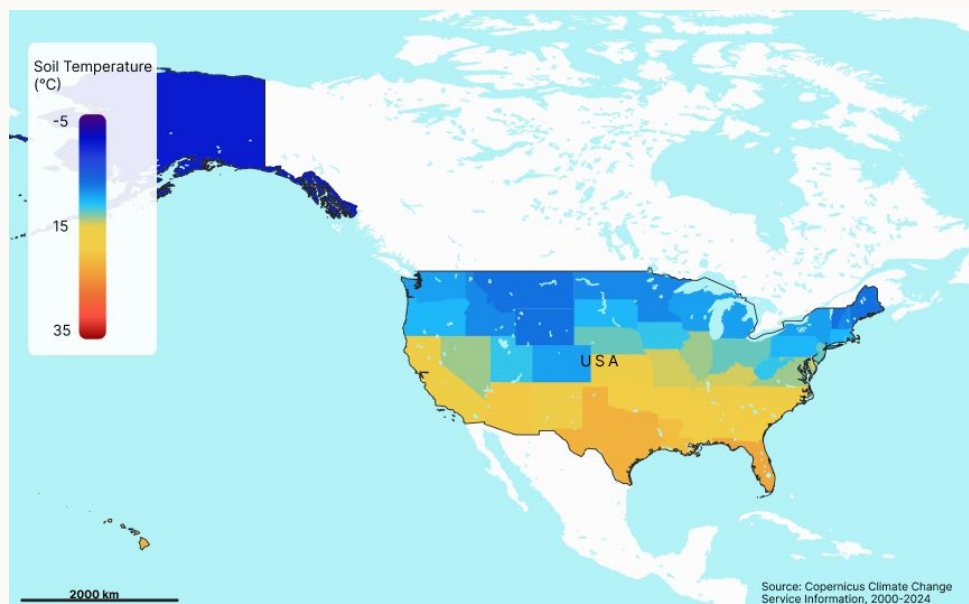
Figure 2. Fraction of biochar carbon (100 years) as a function of H/C ratio and soil temperature



A component of the Decay Rate: the soil temperature

We leverage a third party data from Copernicus Climate Change Service (C3S) (2022) for our soil temperature assessment as seen in figure 3 below. This is to ensure that the soil temperature of biochar's application location claimed by the project is in line with latest verified and established soil temperature data.

Figure 3. Example of soil temperature map for United States of America



Co-Benefits Score

What is it?

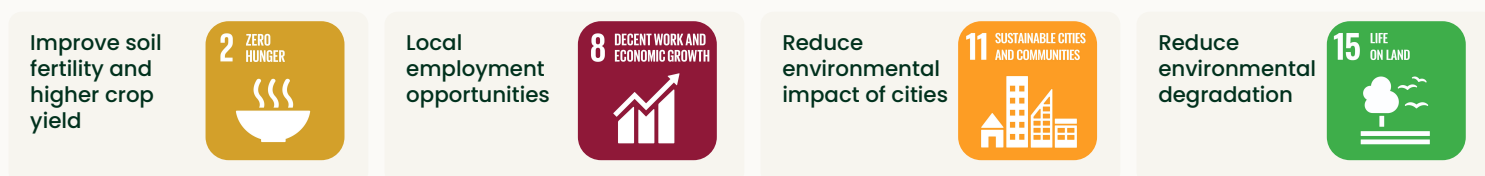
Sylvera's co-benefits rating examines whether the project is implementing activities to support local biodiversity and communities, as well as the scale and likely impact of these activities.

How do we assess the co-benefits of biochar credits?

Sylvera measures the impact biochar project activities have on biodiversity. We leverage data provided by project developers, IUCN data, and IBAT data.

When assessing community impact, we utilize data disclosed by project developers and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) to triangulate a project's community impact.

An example of a biochar projects contribution to biodiversity and community:



BIODIVERSITY

Threats & Safeguards

We assess whether the facility is located in a conservation area. There are no threats associated such as pollutant treatment with the application of biochar in soil or non-soil applications.

Biodiversity Protection

We assess the extent to which the project has contributed to biodiversity loss.

COMMUNITIES

Social Safeguards

To ensure the project aligns with social safeguard principles, we conduct a thorough evaluation of potential risks, including inadequate worker safety, insufficient community engagement, or inequitable benefit-sharing. As part of our assessment, we carefully analyze stakeholder engagement processes and worker safety practices to measure their impact on local communities. These evaluations are integral to understanding and mitigating social risks while fostering positive outcomes for all stakeholders involved.

Sustainable Development Goals

We independently identify which UN SDGs the project is contributing towards by assessing the activities implemented by the project. We determine the relative impact of activities on local communities by scaling the SDG impact against country-level performance, the size of the population affected, and the carbon removals achieved by the project.

Interpreting the Additionality Score



Indicates very high confidence that a project is additional.

Example: The project demonstrates strong evidence that it relies on the sale of carbon credits, meaning that it couldn't have taken place without having access to finance from the VCM.



Indicates high confidence that the project is additional.



Indicates the project is likely additional.

Example: The project does not rely on the sale of carbon credits, meaning that it could take place without access to finance from the VCM, or the project relies heavily on financial grants or subsidies.



Indicates uncertainty about the project's additionality claim.



Indicates we found a serious red flag questioning the project's claims of additionality.

Example: The project does not need to rely on the sale of carbon credits, meaning that it took place without access to finance from the VCM, the project is mandatory by law, or demonstrates double accounting under the different upstream and downstream project activities.

Interpreting the Permanence Score



Indicates very high permanence and low risk, the project carbon credits are very likely to remain valid long-term.

Example: Low hydrogen to carbon ratio indicating high stability risk, together with low natural risks, ideal soil type and application method and low soil temperature for soil application of biochar.



Indicates high permanence, the project carbon credits are likely to remain valid long-term.

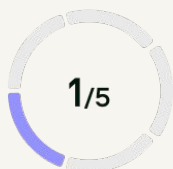


Indicates moderate permanence, the project carbon credits may remain valid long-term.

Example: Moderate hydrogen to carbon ratio indicating moderate stability risk, as well as moderate risk of fires, storms, floods and human activities.



Indicates low permanence, the project carbon credits are unlikely to remain valid long-term.



Indicates very low permanence and high risk, the project carbon credits are highly unlikely to remain valid long-term.

Example: Low biochar stability rate, i.e., higher hydrogen to carbon ratio and high decay rate due to external factors such as higher soil temperature and natural risks.

Interpreting the Co-Benefit Score



Indicates no evidence of materialized harms and the project implementing activities that provide diverse, extensive and well-evidenced benefits to both community biodiversity protection/gain.

Example: The project implements a broad range of SDG activities with extensive reach in the community, employs local communities, ensures sustainable consumption practices, and contributes to other SDG initiatives meaningfully. The project's feedstock also poses low risk to biodiversity conservation, and the project implements environmental safeguards in place to mitigate contaminants and pollution.



Indicates no evidence of materialized harms and strong progression of targeted SDGs, as well as mitigates biodiversity risk; or exceptional benefits in one sub-pillar and moderate benefits in the other.

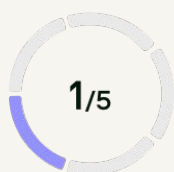


Indicates no materialized harms and the project implements activities that provide moderate benefits for community sustainable development and biodiversity protection/gains

Example: The project implements SDG activities that reasonably match SDG expectations associated with employment, sustainable consumption, and others, as well as implements environmental safeguards in place to mitigate contaminants and pollution.



Indicates no severe materialized harms, but the project implements none or few activities that provide limited benefits to community and/or biodiversity; or, project implementation results in some negative impact alongside the delivery of activities that provide some benefits to community and/or biodiversity.



Indicates project implementation resulted in materialized harm to communities and/or ecosystems and no project activities benefit the community and/or biodiversity; or, materialized harms from project implementation is great enough to negate any positive impacts of project activities aiming at community and/or biodiversity benefits.

Example: The project provides no evidence of its activities meeting the minimum expectation of SDG contribution related to community and there is no evidence of environmental safeguards in place to mitigate contaminants and pollution. Besides that, the feedstock used for biochar production poses a high risk to biodiversity conservation.

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Sylvera is a carbon data platform on a mission to incentivize investment in real climate action. Global corporations, financial institutions, and governments rely on Sylvera to develop and execute their carbon credit strategies, drive measurable progress toward net zero goals, and optimize returns on investment. Co-founded in 2020 by Dr. Allister Furey and Sam Gill, the company is headquartered in London with additional offices in Belgrade, New York, and Singapore.

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